

Critical Event Planning Guide



Resilience System Design and Alignment to Standards

This resilience system has been designed by Risk and Strategic Management, Corp (RSM), a specialist company expert in designing and implementing complex resilience strategies which protect people, facilities, assets, information, operations and organizational reputation. This system has been aligned to the following ISO and BSI standards to ensure it reflects the professional standards and practices of High Reliability Organizations: ISO 31000: Risk management; ISO 22317: Business impact analysis; ISO 22301: Business continuity management; ISO 22320: Emergency management; ISO 34001: Security and resiliency; ISO 22316: Organizational resiliency; and BSI 17091: Crisis management.

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Introduction

The purpose of the *Critical Event Guide* is to give management teams a flexible framework to guide their risk planning and decision-making for both predicted and unpredicted threats. This can be used at either the headquarters or field level in the days, weeks or months leading up to a defined high-risk period or event. This Guide can also be used to support rapid decision-making where an emergent threat occurs.

The use of a checklist structured Guide enables management teams to verify that they have reviewed the full scope of actions potentially required to address a threat, selecting courses of action relevant to the context of each emergency situation. This checklist is not exhaustive and additional considerations and courses of action may be identified by management teams in relation to a specific operating environment and situation.

Action	Required	Considered	Not Required
MANAGEMENT RESPONSIBILITIES			
Scoping, Understanding and Strategic Planning for Crisis Events			
Conduct a Risk Assessment / Business Impact Assessment of possible threats and risks associated with the risk event or period.	☐		
Agree what constitutes a Crisis Event in the context of the organization / activity – and what level of event is likely to occur [1,2,3 ¹].	☐		
Review the Risk Assessment / Business Impact Assessment to identify potential risks and their impacts.	☐		
Establish warning indicators which could provide early warning of a Crisis Event or associated risks. Group these within Alert States.	☐		
Establish triggers connected to warning indicators which initiate a course of action or response measure required, including changing the required 'Response Readiness' time of support services and resources.	☐		
Establish a standard management meeting agenda to review near and medium-term risks at management level meetings.	☐		
Establish risk monitoring plan with allocated responsibilities: local networks, local / international media, outsourced intelligence / risk management providers, outsourced Travel Alert systems etc.	☐		
Assess the disruption to business and operations and how this impacts clients, partners, and other involved stakeholders. Determine any contractual or business implications. Define potential work-arounds and articulate impacts and actions to appropriate parties in a timely manner.	☐		

¹ Ratings: [1] extreme impact, [2] high impact, [3] low impact.

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Action	Required	Considered	Not Required
Crisis Communications and Stakeholder Management			
Consolidate all points of contact potentially involved in, or supportive of, a Crisis Event in a central capture document ² .	☐	☐	☐
Institute a Warden Reporting System using Phone Trees – test the system.	☐	☐	☐
Develop guidelines on media engagement and management, including clearly defined individuals authorized to engage with the media.	☐	☐	☐
Develop formats for [immediate] emergency verbal reporting and [Initial, Update and Final] <i>Situation Reports</i> [SITREPs] to enable the quick and effective sharing of time-sensitive information.	☐	☐	☐
Create redundancies in communication systems, ensuring access to multiple channels of communication, such as: Sat Phones, BGANs, VOIP, local cellphones, cellphones with international roaming capability, tracking and panic devices, VHF and UHF radio systems.	☐	☐	☐
Create resilience in the communication operability and longevity by procuring alternative battery charging options such as car and solar charging options.	☐	☐	☐
Define specific call-in times and call duration protocols to extend the battery life of phones, radios, Sat Phones, BGANs and laptops.	☐	☐	☐
Institute Operational Security [OPSEC] measures to control the passage of information.	☐	☐	☐
Develop or update a <i>Crisis Communications Plan</i> and <i>Critical Stakeholder and Vendor Plan</i> . Assign an individual to be responsible to ensure contact information is validated.	☐	☐	☐
Incident Management			
Develop an <i>Emergency Action Plan</i> comprising Pre-Planned Response [PPR] measures to enable coherent responses to a Crisis Event or associated risks. PPRs should be drafted in relation to each of the risks identified through the Risk Assessment / Business Impact Analysis.	☐	☐	☐
Develop companion Data Capture Reports for each of the PPRs – ensure these are concise and capture the information required to effectively manage and respond to a Crisis Event, including the information required to draft SITREPs ³ .	☐	☐	☐

² Including, but not limited to Headquarters Office and Field staff members [disaggregating CMLT and LIMT members], partners and counterpart organizations, local community groups / leaders, emergency responders / public agencies, local legal counsel, security and logistics providers, risk consulting and advisory services, evacuation insurance providers, emergency evacuation service providers [e.g., Charter Air], designated safe havens, medical facilities.

³ Situation Reports.

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Managing People			
Identify individuals who may be vulnerable [by virtue of medical conditions, impaired sight / hearing / mobility, age, gender, race, ethnicity] – ensure their specific needs are accounted for during management planning. Consider staged or rapid relocations or the delay or cancellation of travel, visits, or events.	☐	☐	☐
Map external stakeholders [including clients, partners, consultants, subcontractors, communities, and families of staff] and internal stakeholders and gather contact information.	☐	☐	☐
Develop a <i>Critical Stakeholder and Vendor Plan</i> to specify how and when stakeholders are to be contacted in the event of a Crisis Event, and specifically who is responsible for engagement and direction. Capture all points of contact in this document and ensure it is valid.	☐	☐	☐
Develop a robust process for ensuring it is possible to establish the identity of all individuals on a site or in an area at a given time – including visitors and contractors.	☐	☐	☐
RESOURCE MANAGEMENT			
Define and engage external service providers, ensuring contracts designate required 'Response Readiness' timeframes that may be shortened as Alert States change ⁴ .	☐	☐	☐
Confirm the ability for vendors to mobilize within accelerated timelines and mobilize additional resources early [such as additional guards, vehicles and drivers or risk advisors].	☐	☐	☐
Define and procure holdings 'on inventory' of stores and equipment, understanding that levels held may increase as Alert States change and that management teams must recognize that other organizations may be responding similarly, creating pressure on these resources, so action to procure must be decisive ⁵ .	☐	☐	☐
Identify key stakeholders and initiate information and resource sharing, situation reporting and requests for direction – including diplomatic, government, client, peer, partners, forums and vendors. Determine where stakeholders are responsible for providing a 'permission' or where a notification is mandatory.	☐	☐	☐

⁴ External service providers include, but are not limited to: local legal counsel, doctors and emergency medical facilities, security guards and close protection services, political and medical evacuation service providers, transport and logistics services, kidnap and ransom specialists, liaison and facilitation support.

⁵ Stores and equipment include, but are not limited to: heating and cooking fuels and power; medical supplies; food and water stocks, being ideally dry or tinned rations; vehicles, fuels, maps and emergency stores; ropes and emergency signalling equipment; solar chargers and emergency hand-cranked radios; communications equipment; tents, water purification tablets or devices, sleeping bags, rucksacks and other camping gear.

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Action	Required	Considered	Not Required
Ensure all emergency assets, equipment and stores are secured and are serviceable. Ensure all vehicles are fully serviced, oiled, fueled and readied for use.	☐	☐	☐
Logistics Management			
Develop mapping identifying key nodal points of relevance in any planned relocation / evacuation [safe havens, muster points, assembly areas, border crossing points, airfields/strips, ferry crossings / fording points], and the primary and alternate routes between these nodal points are defined and articulated.	☐	☐	☐
Ensure there is sufficient lift capacity to move people and assets, with contingency measures to account for vehicle breakdowns.	☐	☐	☐
Ensuring drivers and staff have received the correct training and briefings, including on the designated primary and alternate evacuation routes, safe havens and border crossing points.	☐	☐	☐
Financial Planning			
Consider the minimum cash reserves needed to pay staff wages / contractors and cover costs for emergency equipment and stores procurement in a deteriorating risk environment, especially where the economy becomes cash-based.	☐	☐	☐
Implement contingency planning to enable emergency cash to be physically carried into the country where standard bank withdrawals and wire transfer options are not possible. Identify alternative mechanisms of accessing finances, including through 3 rd parties or wire transfer agencies.	☐	☐	☐
Consider pre-paying staff to reduce risks of financial disruptions.	☐	☐	☐
Assign a Cost Code to account for Crisis Event costs which may be reimbursable by the client or insurance. This should track labor, procurements and services.	☐	☐	☐
Emergency [Contingency] Travel Planning			
Ensure visas are secured to enable overland extraction to neighboring countries.	☐	☐	☐
Pre-book flight tickets [rolling tickets] with bookings updated on a regular basis [in a rapidly deteriorating risk environment air tickets may become exceptionally difficult to secure].	☐	☐	☐
FACILITIES and ASSET MANAGEMENT			
Conduct safety and security assessments of sites and facilities [including residential accommodation] in light of Risk Assessment / Business Impact Analysis to determine ongoing suitability.	☐	☐	☐

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Develop and exercise facility lockdown procedures ⁶ .	☐	☐	☐
Develop and conduct tabletop exercising of facility temporary evacuation and reoccupation procedures ⁷ .	☐	☐	☐
Identify a 'Stay-Behind Party' to manage facilities and resources during an evacuation. Establish asset and equipment needs, safety and security requirements, and reporting protocols.	☐	☐	☐
Back-up and transfer electronic data [including scanning hard copy data]. Define destruction protocols and triggers of sensitive electronic and paper-based documents and data.	☐	☐	☐
POLICIES, PLANS and PROCEDURES			
Ensure all safety, security and emergency management documents are reviewed, updated and exercised.	☐	☐	☐
Develop standalone Critical Event Management Plan to define courses of action and management roles and responsibilities – ensure this is shared with all appropriate parties.	☐	☐	☐
TRAINING and AWARENESS			
Conduct scheduled staff training, exercising and drills in relation to prioritized risks.	☐	☐	☐
Implement just-in-time training for impacted management teams responsible for security and safety planning and management.	☐	☐	☐
Implement just-in-time training for security managers and focal points responsible for security and safety planning and management.	☐	☐	☐
Conduct joint CMLT and LIMT tabletop exercises in relation to prioritized risks.	☐	☐	☐
Conduct staff exercises and drills in relation to prioritized risks which are triggered by changes in the Alert State	☐	☐	☐
Implement driver training and briefings on vehicle maintenance, emergency stores, evacuation routes and key point locations, and security response protocols.	☐	☐	☐
Implement guard force and mobile security team training and briefings on facility and transport security requirements and emergency response protocols.	☐	☐	☐

⁶ Facility is capable of being adequately secured, including through the allocation of additional guard force personnel, and the definition of zones within the site that have enhanced security where high value / critical assets may be required to remain in place, such as server rooms; designate a Stay Behind Party where a partial evacuation is warranted; relocate / ship stores and equipment away from the facility; ensure facility is capable of being self-sustaining where fully / partly occupied – power, heat, water, food, communications.

⁷ Where a site is to be fully evacuated, institute a Destruction Plan [burning / shredding information and, in certain circumstances, rendering assets and equipment inoperable]; take an inventory of assets; if possible, engage 'caretaker' services and / or hire security guards; turn off all power, water, gas; dispose of all perishable items; securely lock / seal site and individual buildings within the facility; on reoccupation, undertake advance party visit to establish reoccupation requirements.

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Action	Required	Considered	Not Required
Conduct specialized training for 'Special Teams' in relation to prioritized Crisis Events [e.g., search and rescue teams, firefighting using SCBA, confined space or high angle rescues, security team responses to perimeter breaches / attacks / suspect devices / evacuation convoy drills].	☐	☐	☐

Other Considerations